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ANGRY WORDS Law students demand justice for the Kasba rape victim in Kolkata, Jun. 30

he broke by asking to speak with her alone. In a quiet passageway, he professed "love" and proposed marriage. She demurred gently, explaining she already had a boyfriend. Back in the hub, the unspoken siege deepened. After 6 pm, Monojit stopped a few kids who tried to exit. At 7:30 pm, the outgoing secretary excused herself. The victim's path was blocked, the door locked.

At Monojit's first assault, she had a panic attack and "shortness of breath". She pleaded to be taken to a hospital. Denied. Asked for her inhaler. Reluctantly given. In the confusion, she came out, but found the main gate locked.

Monojit finally raped her in the guard's room, trying to hit her with a hockey stick, warning her boyfriend would be killed and parents jailed if she dared to tell anyone. The guard stood outside, along with two hench boys—Pramit, 20, and Zaib, 19—who also took videos and photos. At 10:50 pm, battered and broken, she was finally released into the humid Kolkata night.

Once out of danger, she chose courage and registered a complaint. Bitter irony in her words, she says: "A law student, I am the victim now. I want justice." The trio was arrested on June 26. Medical tests and surveillance footage corroborated much of her story.

Monojit's sordid past and political links are no secret—nor the impunity that came with it (see *Accused No. 1*). His social media pages are filled with pictures of him with TMC biggies like Firhad Hakim, Chandrima Bhattacharya, Abhishek Banerjee. That was enough to create echoes of R.G. Kar.

As students, lawyers and political parties protest, the college is closed indefinitely—but accusations and counters swarm about. A BJP fact-finding team accused the state of trying to silence the survivor's family. The TMC, in turn, cited the rising sexual crime graph in Madhya Pradesh: 7,294 cases in 2024, 20 rapes a day. Only silence, and security, it seems, are in short supply. ■

▶ BIHAR

DOLE DRUMS

Nitish Kumar unveils a cornucopia of promises for the youth, women, devouts, pensioners, village heads

By **Amitabh Srivastava**

IT'S THE TIME TO PLEASE ALL THE PEOPLE, at least this one time. As assembly election nears, Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar has set off a volley of welfare steps, each tailored to a distinct vote bloc. The big one came on June 24, as his cabinet nearly trebled monthly social security pensions: from Rs 400 to Rs 1,100. Ordinarily a stickler for protocol, Nitish didn't wait this time. On June 21, he announced the enhanced pension would start getting credited to over 10.9 million beneficiary accounts by July.

Opposition leader Tejashwi Yadav was quick to decry the idea as a poor copy, pointing out that he had promised a pension hike to Rs 1,500 in December. But



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POPULAR MOVE Bihar CM Nitish Kumar hands an appointment letter to a police constable in Patna, Jun. 28